

Rule Two: Never Answer on the First Ring

Do-yun ("Doha")

Nobody warns you that being a professional singer comes with no off switch. There's no on switch either, which you'd think would balance out. It doesn't.

Music happens to me the way weather happens to other people. I hum over sinks. I hum in lifts. I have harmonised with a refrigerator for a full minute in my sleep — Sun has video, Sun has shown people the video, and the worst part is I'm good in it. So you'd assume that the one place sound is actually supposed to arrive on command — a booth at four in the morning, foam on the walls, a floor that eats your footsteps, a microphone standing there in the dark like it's got all night — you'd assume it would come.

It does not. It hasn't for months. The booth wants a song and I've got nothing but breath going out the same shape it went in, and a very expensive room drinking even that. You can hear the room when you stop: the foam swallowing everything, the faint electric nothing of the live feed, my own pulse loud in the cans. Silence that costs by the hour.

I know why. I'm not saying it. Not in here, not with the door shut and no one to hear it but the equipment, because saying a thing out loud is how you make it true, and I've got enough true things this week.

The phone lit up on the stool. Hyun.

I let it ring twice. Rule two of being me, somewhere under the rule about the first ring of anything: answering fast tells a man you were waiting by the phone, and I have spent fifteen years not being a man anyone can read off a ringtone.

"You're not asleep," Hyun said. Not a question.

"Neither are you."

"I'm not asleep because the studio app says Booth C went live at three-forty and never went dark, and the last time you kept these hours I learned a brand-new phrase. Stress fracture. Lovely. Really rolls off." A pause, and then the handler went out of his voice and the brother climbed in. "Have you eaten."

It's never about food. We built that question in a trainee dorm a hundred years ago — him a dozen years up on me and already half a manager, cutting his one meal in half so the kids he was minding had something to train on.

"I ate," I said.

"You're a liar and a disgrace and I've covered for both." Almost fond. "I told Noh it's

vocal rest. Doctor's orders, the full tragic violin. He bought it because in fifteen years I have never once handed him a reason not to, so do me the courtesy of not making me a liar retroactively. Come back when you can stand a room full of people. Not before." A breath. "But Do-yun. I can only hold what I can see. Don't go dark on me again."

He hung up before I could answer, which was a kindness, because the answer would've had to be a promise, and I'm fresh out.

Vocal rest. That's the lie. It's a good lie — the best ones are mostly true, and there is, technically, a thing wrong near my throat. The doctors looked. They put their soft careful faces very close to mine and found nothing to find, because there's no nodule on a man who put his fist through a year-end party. That's the true part. The right hand healed crooked — there's a little white ridge across the knuckles now, a small country with one citizen, where it split on a senior director's teeth.

But that's not the reason the song won't come. The reason the song won't come is dumber than a broken hand, and I'd genuinely rather have the hand explanation, so let's do the hand explanation in public and keep the real one in here, where it's just me and a microphone that can't testify.

The real one is a girl in a convenience store. Three years ago. In the kind of rain that comes down dead straight and sounds like applause that's forgotten how to stop.

I'd left the car two streets back that night — left the car, the name, the whole apparatus of being me, slipped the men whose entire job is to make sure I'm never alone, which is harder than it sounds and which is why the coat lost a shoulder going over a fence I'll deny ever climbing. Soaked through. Going under, quietly, the way you can in a crowd of nobody. I ducked under the first roof I found, which had a leak ticking into a bucket and a girl behind the counter with her sleeve wet to the elbow, and I put coins down for the worst coffee in the case because I wanted something to hold.

She looked up. One look. Quick, level, the kind that reads a person clean through and isn't selling anything back — and it went through me like a key turning a lock I hadn't known was set.

I get looked at for a living. Tens of thousands at once, looked at until being-looked-at stopped landing as anything at all. Nobody had seen me in years. She saw me — the wet, the wreck, the thing going down behind my face — and wanted exactly nothing for it. Took the cold can out of my hand, set a scalding one down where it had been, pushed my money back across the counter with two fingers, and when I tried again she said it's still on me without even looking up, and turned to straighten a shelf that did not need straightening. Done with me. On to the next ordinary thing.

That's it. That's the whole crime. People have handed me cars. People would maim each

other to borrow my name for an afternoon. Nobody had ever put something warm in my hands in the dark, asked for nothing, and turned away like I was already forgotten.

And her eyes. Look — I'm aware of how this sounds. I'm aware I am a grown man who has organised three years of his interior life around ninety seconds and a hot can of coffee, and that if I said any of this aloud the kindest available diagnosis would be concussion. But her eyes did a thing I have no word for and I have looked into a professional quantity of eyes. Green going gold toward the middle, the gold ringed so clean it looked done on purpose, like sun through a leaf pooling where the light caught. Not a colour. A depth. The kind you fall a little way into before you've decided to look.

I went back the next week. She was gone. Fill-in shifts — one week of somebody else's hours, moved on before her name stuck to the place, how she travelled through the world, never anywhere long enough to be found, all of it feeding some private sum I couldn't see. I went back to that store more times than I'll admit on tape, bought the worst coffee in the case off whoever was working, and stood under the awning drinking it in the rain like the village idiot, like the weather that delivered her once might be talked into an encore.

The song started that same week and stopped exactly where she did.

It started a week after. Not at the counter — on a set, under hot lights, when a runner handed me a canned coffee out of a convenience-store bag and the smell of it put me back under that awning so hard the floor tilted, and the music just came. Whole. Uninvited. Eight bars with the rain folded through them, the best thing I'd made in years, arriving in the ninety seconds between camera setups with a stylist's hands in my hair and nothing in reach to write on — and by the time we broke I grabbed for it and it was gone. Gone like she was gone. I doubled over. I physically folded in half over the loss of a tune, in front of witnesses, and told them it was a cramp.

So I made a vow, ringing with it like a struck glass: never again. Not one bar. Whatever comes, wherever it comes, it goes down now — receipt, napkin, the back of my hand, a fogged window — before the world can take it back.

I have kept this vow the way other men keep religion. The inside pocket of every coat I own holds the evidence: a fat soft brick of napkins and ticket stubs and torn-off corners, three years of a woman I can't name written in a language that reads, to anyone who finds it, as a musician's filth. I have a hoard. It's deeply unwell. I'm not stopping.

The song is a private problem with a girl-shaped hole in the end of it, and it has been my problem for three years, and it is, frankly, the manageable one.

The voice is the other thing. The voice broke at the party.

They sent me to the year-end party — sent; I don't go to those, I get deployed to them

like a centrepiece that waves. Three hundred people hired to be seen and a handful hired to be invisible, and somewhere in the invisible third a director three drinks deep put his hand somewhere a hand has no business going, on one of the women the night had hired and would never name. I never got her face. She was turned away, the room was a churn of bodies, and all I clocked was the hand, and the casual entitled nothing-of-it of it, and the fact that not one person in that bright expensive room was going to move.

So I moved. I'd like to tell you I had a plan. I had a downbeat. My body was across that floor before any part of me filed the paperwork, and the next thing I owned was the sound, and then three sets of hands hauling me off, and a ridge starting to form across my knuckles that's still there.

And then the machine did what the machine does, which is erase. By morning there was an NDA and a number pressed into a stranger's hand to turn her back into a stranger, her name lifted clean off the night's record, a bright clean story about an idol's exhaustion laid over the top like a tablecloth over a hole in the table. My own mother signed off on the cleanup before she got round to asking whether my hand was broken — because a nameless girl attached to her son's fist was a grenade rolled under the merger, and the merger does not get endangered, not by a scandal, and certainly not by a stranger.

That's the part the doctors can't find. Not a nodule. My fist is an asset to be managed and a girl is a cost to be disappeared, and I was expected to wake up, ice the asset, and go sing. The voice is the product. After that I couldn't hand it over — you try giving a room your whole open throat the week you learn precisely what they'll do with anyone who stands too close to you.

Vocal rest. See? Half true. Half of it is even the right half.

Tuesday my mother had me to dinner. The table seats twelve and was laid for two, and the merger sat between us where a third setting would go, the way a draft sits in a room: unmentioned, fully present. She waited until the soup was cleared. She always waits until the soup is cleared. News travels better on an empty bowl; she taught me that the way other mothers teach you to look both ways.

"The Seo girl," she said. "You'll meet her properly at the engagement dinner. The families have settled the date."

Not would you. Not what do you think. Settled. I set my spoon down at the precise angle she trained into me at six.

"I haven't agreed."

"You weren't asked to." Kindly. That's the part that takes the air. "You were asked the year you turned six, when I put you in the right school. You were asked at twelve, at the audition. You've been agreeing your whole life, Do-yun — I can't imagine why you'd pick now to develop a position, when it's finally about to be worth something."

"Eomma. I'm twenty-six."

"I'm aware. I was there." A pause, the spoon set down, and then the round she keeps chambered for when nothing else will fire. "Do you know what I had at twenty-six? You. A room we heated one wall of. And a list of which bills could slide another month before the lights went off — I knew that list the way you know your scales. I have spent thirty years making certain you'd never have to learn it. The Seo merger is the last line of it. After this you are safe, in a way no one can take back, ever." Her napkin found its crease. "And you'll sit at my table and tell me you'd trade that for a feeling. Wear the grey at the dinner, not the black. The black makes you look like you're mourning."

And she was gone, and the merger kept its seat, and I sat there being the only thing standing between my mother and a poverty she can still feel breathing on the back of her neck. She isn't wrong about the cold. She's only wrong about which cold.

I don't sleep, so I walk. Every walk is half a search I keep swearing I've quit.

Four nights ago the walking took me past a diner — fluorescent light spilling yellow across a wet road, the hum of the sign loud in an empty street — and I went in for a coffee I didn't want, which is the entire basis of my relationship with coffee.

She was behind the counter.

I knew her in a half-second and it wasn't the face I knew, it was the eyes — that exact gold ringed clean, lifting off a customer's cup, catching the cheap diner light and doing the leaf-and-sun thing across a room three years and a city wide of the last time. Older. Thinner. The tired gone past what a shift does and into what a life does. And the song — the dead, frozen, girl-shaped song — moved. Two bars. Right there over the smell of burnt coffee, two new measures unspooling like the lock had found a second pin, the first new music I'd made since the party, and I had a receipt and a pencil stub out and against the wall of a shut shop before I was back on the street, the staff scratched out fast and ugly in the wet, caught and pocketed before the city could take it back. Got it. Kept it. That part's reflex now.

I did not go to her. I took the booth at the back like a coward with excellent reasons. I'd learned it in NDA ink a few weeks before: the single most dangerous thing that can

happen to a person on this earth is to be caught standing next to me. I'd watched my world do that to a girl whose face I never even saw. I was not going to do it to the one whose eyes I'd kept for three years. So I drank a coffee I didn't want and watched her work and left too much money under the cup, which is the only language I had and the wrong one, and walked back out into the cold humming two bars that stopped, as they always stop, at the exact cliff where she isn't.

Which is how I ended up, against every rule that's ever kept me alive, renting a room.

Not a unit of my own — I've got those, glass boxes with my name in the registry and a guard in the lobby and not one human thing inside them. A room. In a real apartment. With a real stranger on the other side of a real wall living an ordinary life I have never once been allowed within reach of.

Hyun fought me. It isn't secure, there's no vetting, the other tenant's an unknown — right up until he read the listing aloud.

"Tenant's a Yun Jae-wu," he said, and I heard the exact instant the fight went out of him.

Because Yun Jae-wu reads as a man's name. And the one law neither of us will break — the third rail, the bright humming wire — is that an idol does not share a wall with a woman. A man on the other side of the plaster isn't the third rail. A man is just a stranger. A man is, in fact, two stolen months of quiet and a door I can bolt from the inside, which Hyun wanted for me more than he wanted to win the argument, because he could see the same ledge coming he saw the night of the party and he'd rather I be standing on a cheap floor than that one.

I signed it tonight without reading past the address. It doesn't matter where it is. Anywhere with one ordinary person on the far side of the wall who has never heard my name. For two months I get to be a man and not a maison. A person and not a product.

I put my fingers back to the strings.

The rain. The can. The coins pushed back. Three years. A diner counter and the gold catching the light. A name I still don't have.

I let myself think of her — on purpose, this time — and quietly, with no one to hear it but a dead room that can't tell anyone, something came. Not the whole thing. Never the whole thing without her. Just the fragment, the rain-bars and the two new ones after, true as far as they go and then stopping clean at the edge of where she isn't.

My hands went still on the wood.

I should write it down. But that's the one thing I won't put on paper — there are truths

you don't leave lying around where your mother's people might find them, and that one I'd bury myself. The bars, I keep. The wet receipt smoothed flat on my knee, the notes copied clean before they blur, folded into the inside pocket with the rest of the hoard — three years of a woman in a language nobody can read as anything but a mess.

The notes I keep.

The name of what they are, I carry in my mouth, where it's safe, and where, four nights ago and one signed lease later, it has very quietly started to feel less like a confession and more like an address.